

PTI

KEEPING COUNT PM Modi with ally and Bihar CM Nitish Kumar at an event in Madhubani, Apr. 24

under a Mandal 2.0 banner. Result: the BJP tally dropped to 36 (from 62) out of 80 seats, while the SP-Congress combine moved up to 43. Post-poll data showed an erosion of the BJP's OBC base—NDA support among Kurmi-Koeris fell by 19 per cent, and among other non-Yadav OBCs by 13 per cent. Even 'upper OBC' support dropped by 4 per cent.

Meanwhile, the caste dynamics in Maharashtra added their own momentum. Dominant Marathas have long demanded reservation, citing agrarian distress. They were granted a 16 per cent quota in 2018 but the apex court struck it down in 2021 for breaching the 50 per cent cap and lacking social backwardness criteria. This reignited tensions, with Marathas seeking OBC status and existing OBC groups opposing dilution of their share. The BJP, now back in power in the state with Maratha-heavy allies (Ajit Pawar, Eknath Shinde), is caught in the middle. A caste census offers a way out—providing data to assess genuine backwardness, and potentially appeasing both sides. It also addresses a 2021 court ruling that scrapped OBC quotas in local bodies for lack of data, sparking unrest. By backing the census, the BJP can promise OBCs data-backed return of local quotas while assuring Marathas that their claims will be fairly evaluated—a classic case of its micro-OBC management strategy.

BIHAR POLLS ARE DUE THIS YEAR, AND THE NOD FOR A CASTE CENSUS MAY HELP THE BJP RECLAIM SOME GROUND IN THE OBC NARRATIVE

RISKS AND REPERCUSSIONS

Critics point to the practical difficulties of a caste census in a vast country like India, such as the complexity of defining and enumerating thousands of sub-castes. Past attempts had been mired by logistical and administrative quagmires, the very reason cited by the Registrar General of India for rejecting a plan to conduct a caste census in 2010.

Meanwhile, by backing a caste census now, the BJP is walking a tightrope with its traditional support base—upper-caste Hindus and the aspirational urban middle class. The party's promise of a merit-based, unified India that rises above caste divisions has long resonated with these groups. With the 'pivot', there'll be growing unease that the caste census data could justify expanded quotas, shrinking the jobs and education space for upper castes. Some forward caste groups are already warning of a 'Mandal 2.0 moment', harking to the '90s backlash to the original Mandal Commission. Sceptics also fear the data would open a Pandora's box, fuelling demands for fresh or larger quotas not just from OBCs but also forward castes claiming disadvantage, and spark intra-caste rivalries, as subgroups seek distinct benefits. As a safety valve, the BJP may well cite the 10 per cent EWS (Economically Weaker Section) quota it introduced in 2019 for poor general category citizens.

The post-census phase could also prove volatile, as has been the case in Karnataka. Its caste survey exposed the dominance of the Lingayats and the Vokkaligas and recommended reclassifying Kurubas under a new MBC (Most Backward Classes) category with a steep quota hike. Even Congress leaders from the dominant castes criticised the findings, highlighting how such caste data can trigger inter-group tensions.

If there is a respite, it will be in the fact that any policy move based on caste census data, be it raising quotas or redefining categories, is unlikely to come swiftly. The delay will allow the BJP to claim credit for the census without immediately upsetting its upper-caste base. It will still be a tightrope walk: act too slowly and face Opposition charges of tokenism; act too fast and risk backlash if data suggests expanding OBC quotas beyond 50 per cent. To avoid this bind, the BJP may fall back on the Rohini Commission's sub-categorisation framework to target benefits to the most backward OBCs without raising the overall quota. The Commission's 2023 report found that less than 1 per cent of OBC sub-groups corner half the benefits, a finding that aligns with BJP's non-dominant caste outreach strategy.

Along with the caste survey, the Modi government will also handle other curve balls such as delimitation, expansion of Lok Sabha seats and women's reservation after the upcoming Census. Bhupender Yadav says the BJP is mindful of this. "The Census captures more than just caste—it includes gender, health, geography and education. Women's reservation, too, hinges on the census as does delimitation," he notes.

To be sure, the road ahead for the BJP is complex. The party must now juggle the demands of its Mandal constituency—seeking caste justice—and its Kamandal base—rooted in Hindutva. How successfully it balances these competing forces will determine the next chapter of its politics. ■